Brother

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36727570.

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Some mentions of assault - non graphic, Happy little family, The Light, Sits between Mother and Little Sister

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Part 4 of Family Matters

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by limey_limey

Summary

The Light will not be extinguished.

Notes

The next part of the series that started with Child.

this fits between Mother and Little Sister.

UPDATE - I actually hadn't realised I had started this pic until somebody made a comment on it! I thought it was only planned. I have had a real block BUT am now back into writing and will get back to this once my new fit has been posted.

Update April 27th 2025 - I have been building back into writing after a tumultuous couple of years personally and professionally and feel confident to start working on this again! If anyone cares there should be updates here in May (I actually found my Brother bible and have started work after re-reading everything I have written in this timeline to get back into the characters heads).

Chapter 1

Catra laid on the bed, legs dangling off the edge idly kicking her heels against the box-spring. Her arm was held up towards the ceiling and she was examining the appendage closely, twisting it this way and that as though she had never seen it before. Even the off-key warbling of Adora in the shower couldn't distract her. She began to extend and retract her claws, humming thoughtfully.

The thrumming of the shower stopped, along with Adora's tuneless ditty and Catra propped herself up on her elbows and turned her head to the bathroom door. She loved the way Adora just did everything with so much focus whether it was teaching kids or having a shower. She really squeezed the most out of everything. Their life together hadn't been an easy road but things certainly seemed to be going well right now.

"Hey, Adora!" she called out to the other woman and heard a grunt in reply, a sure sign the blond was deep into her teeth cleaning ritual. "Should I shave my arm?" She flopped back on to the bed after the words had left her lips.

"Mmwhay?" Catra sprang back up into a sitting position, the sheets rustling as she moved, when she heard the garbled words from her girlfriend.

The feline smiled goofily at the sight that met her eyes. Adora was standing in the open doorway, toothbrush poking out of her mouth and foaming at the mouth like she had rabies. Her hair was damp and curling around her neck and clinging to her cheeks. Pyjamas clung to her damp breast and stomach and Catra felt herself start to smirk. She coupled the expression with a quirked eyebrow and waited for Adora to repeat her exclamation sans toothbrush.

Adora ducked back into the bathroom and reappeared again a few seconds later, clean faced and still obviously bamboozled. Catra

simply looked expectantly back at her, tail sweeping across the cotton sheets with a faint whooshing sound.

"Why would you shave your arm?" That Adora was horrified by the idea was clear in how fast she was speaking and Catra couldn't help but ease to her feet and saunter over to the slightly taller woman and reached out to grasp both her hands, leading her back to the bed and sat her down on the edge before standing in front of her and holding out her right arm.

"I don't WANT to shave my arm. The producers are 'asking'," she made the most obnoxious air quotes possible and Adora grin one's at her and rolled her eyes. "Apparently the prosthetics they want to use won't work with fur."

"Can't they use a sock like the one that they green screen your tail with?" Without seeming to notice she reached out for the appendage in question that had been idly weaving at the feline's side, and began to pet the soft fur.

"Apparently not," as she spoke, Catra moved forward and straddled her girl's lap, careful not to pull her tail from the soft grip the human had on it. She settled herself with her legs either side of Adora's thighs careful not to put all of her, deceptively heavy, weight on the human. Her hands reached up and started to play with damp golden hair. "I asked the same. They said it's in sections that need to be applied separately. It looks amazing, they've showed me a mock up. They told me the glue would tear out my fur and they're worried a glove would have to be so tight it would restrict my movements and it wouldn't read as real."

Adora basked in the attention, listening attentively to the other woman's words. Being in films was such a peculiar world in a lot of ways; one day Catra was a race car driver, the next a soldier and then she'd come home with fake blood still hiding in her fur. Since moving from stunt work to acting, she'd been busier than ever but they still made time for each other. In comparison Adora's work as a teacher was relatively hum drum but she loved

the children and appreciated how Catra supported her marking and planning as best the once-upon-a-time runaway could.

Adora let go of the captured tail and moved her hand to run up the arm in question, ruffling the fur she did so, coming to rest cupping the shoulder. She examined how the short fur brushed her fingers. It was a quintessential part of this resilient, slightly fractured woman; another thing making her stand out in a crowded world. The idea of bare skin being under her hand made her shiver in disgust, Catra feeling it covered the hand on her shoulder with her own.

"Hey, what's the matter?" Catra's voice was warm as she ducked her head to catch Adora's eye and the other woman felt abashed.

"The idea of you without fur is just kinda creepy." She knew that she was blushing, embarrassed by her revelation.

"You're such a dummy," affection dropped from Catra's voice as she leaned forward and captured Adora's lips in a luxurious kiss that saw her map the planes of the other woman's mouth, careful not to get carried away with her rough tongue. They'd long ago learned that lesson the hard way. When she pulled away the blond was blushing even brighter and dazzled. "You're all minty." They smiled at each other and Catra encouraged the taller woman to lay back on the bed.

Catra dashed to the bathroom to do her own nighttime routine at double speed, before flicking off the light and joining her love under the sheets. They arranged themselves under the cool linens, Adora sprawled across the mattress on her back taking up most of the space while Catra curled up into her, legs pulled up and head and arm resting across the other woman. Catra began to purr into the space between Adora's neck and jaw, knowing that it would help her love to sleep. Adora wasn't always the easiest sleeper, her mind too busy to shut down and this helped.

Long fingers ran through the fur on the arm slung across her stomach, feeling the muscles shift underneath. She fought the

seductive pull of the purr that was lulling her to sleep as she thought about the prospect of Catra having to take a razor and sheer off her fur. It was a wonder that as they grew up Shadow Weaver hadn't tried to do it herself, she realised. She had always hated Catra's animalistic appearance and her fur had been one of the older woman's biggest bug-bears. It was probably just oversight that had left the girl with her fur intact.

"Do you really want to do this part?" Her words seemed to startle the woman half on top of her, who pulled away so that she could raise herself up on one elbow and look down into blue eyes.

"I mean, it's the biggest part I've been offered so far and I really like the director. So sure, I want the part. I mean, it's not going to make me a household name or anything." She pulled herself up to sit cross legged beside the prone woman, knees touching her girlfriend's arm.

Catra studied Adora's face, could see her thinking. "What's going on in that big head?"

Adora stuck her tongue out at the familiar tease about her big forehead, it had been something Catra had done since they were kids. She pulled herself up to the headboard and sat back against it so that they were face to face again. She studied the feline, fur tufting around the collar and shoulders of there vest that she slept in. She looked cute, though Adora would never tell her as it riled the other woman to hear herself called that.

"I think that if this is important to you, then you should do it. It's only like somebody shaving their head for a part, right? It'll grow back."

"Are you sure you're going to be all right with having an odd armed girlfriend?" Catra seemed more bothered by how she would feel than herself. It was sweet but it just reminded the human woman uncomfortably of their childhood dynamic.

“You could look like a plucked turkey and I would love you!” The beaming smile the words garnered was irresistible and the blond surged forward, taking the more muscular woman by surprise and getting the upper hand, managing to pin her to the bed and clamber on top of her.

“Plucked turkey’s turn you on, huh?” Catra’s purr was undercut by the giggles that started as Adora began to tickle her.

Soon they were rolling around the bed, each trying to get the upper hand, until Adora’s top found its way to the floor while she straddled the furred muscular body beneath her, and all thoughts of ticking changed to something much more pleasurable. Astride a smirking Catra, whose hands were grasping her waist as she began to grind up into her, she felt her skin flush. Adora surged forward, almost head butting the prone woman in her haste, fisting her hands in her hair and sealing their lips together in a hungry kiss that left both women writhing and wanting more.

Javier walked out of his classroom and started to make his way to the familiar room down the hall. The bell had pealed proclaiming the end of the day and his friends had rushed out of the building, a wave of shouting and laughing children ready to be whisked away by harried parents. He’d wandered out with his little group of best friends, something he hadn’t thought he would have a couple of years ago. Then he had been the little odd eyed, furry freak. Now he was surprisingly popular. It had turned out that his mother’s genes meant that he was fast and agile and since he had joined a few of the sports teams he’s gained a whole new group of friends.

He waved as his friends drifted off with parents and babysitters. Soon, he was left alone at the school gates. There were a few other stragglers throwing around a ball in the playground while they waited for parents who were caught up in traffic or meetings, or who just didn’t want to go home just yet. He called out to the small group and they happily shouted back but rather than

making his way over to them he turned and headed back into the school building. He passed several teachers who smiled and nodded at him, used to seeing the boy wandering the halls after hours.

Javier's first stop was to pop his head around the open door to Perfuma's classroom. He spotted the lanky woman in the far corner of the room, humming while she watered and pruned the array of potted plants that always made her classroom seem so welcoming. He watched for a moment before he called out into the room, careful to knock o the doorframe first so he wouldn't startle her. He'd done that a couple of times in the past, forgetting that he was almost as light footed as his feline mother.

"Hi Aunt Perfuma!" The teacher spun and sent him a warm smile and a little wave.

"Hello Javier, how are you today?" They didn't always see each other every day, she wasn't his teacher, but she was always happy to see him.

"I'm great. Mom told me to ask you if you and Scorpia would like to come for dinner on Sunday?" He knew that his mom could just call or text his aunts, but he loved that she gave him responsibility to do things like this. He may only be eight, but he liked to feel like he was taking care of the people in his family too.

"I'll talk to Scorpia when I get home tonight. Thank you for asking. How was your spelling test today?" Javier beamed as he told her how many he had got correct and which ones he was going to try to improve next time. As she listened, Perfuma moved to her desk and rifled around in a drawer coming away with a red sucker that she offered to the boy.

"Thanks Aunt P." He pulled off the wrapper and put it in the wast paper basket before shoving the sweet treat into his mouth. He was long used to the healthy options that Perfuma always have, so was prepared for the slightly bitter flavour in his mouth. "I'll see you later!"

He dashed out of the room, hearing the goodbye Perfuma sent him echo behind him in the corridor. He ran to a closed blue door, it was fun to be in the school by himself, he'd be told off for running in the halls normally. He didn't bother knocking this time, he barged through the door and made a beeline to the woman hunched over her desk with a pencil tapping at her lips. When he got close enough, she put the pen down and he jumped up onto her lap and gave her a hug.

"Hi Javi, where have you been?" Adora smiled at her son, he was already so tall that sitting on her lap they were eye to eye and his legs dangled awkwardly. She loved that he still liked to cuddle as much now as he had when she had met a quiet little six year old. He was already eight and she had missed so much of his early life.

"Walked out with my friends and then went to see Aunt Perfuma. She gave me this!" He brandished the wet, glistening ball of the sucker, crossing his eyes and sticking out his blue tinged tongue. They might be sugar free but he could still be gross.

"Lovely." Adora used her best flat teacher voice, before breaking into a grin and making as if she was going to lick his treat. Which of course would be the most horrific thing that could ever happen.

"Mom! Stop being so weird!" He squealed and scampered away to the other side of the room, poking his tongue out again as they both laughed.

"I won't be long, Javi I just have one more lesson to plan. Do you want an apple to go with that?" She reached into her bag and pulled out a shiny red sphere. It was cliche she knew, teacher with an apple but she just really loved the fruit. She threw it to the ever growing boy who snatched it out of the air.

"Thanks Mom!" He took a huge bite out of the fruit, enjoying the loud crunch that filled the air. His sharp, jagged teeth made short work of it and he was soon throwing it in the trash can next to the teacher's desk.

In the last two years a lot of things had happened to change the boys life. Some of it traumatic and dangerous, but it didn't seem so bad when he weighed it against getting a new parent. When had first met the woman who was now his mom, she had been his favourite teacher and he had been a very different little boy. He wasn't sure if it was what he and his family had gone through, or how happy his mama was now that they were a family of three, he just knew that this was the best time he could ever remember. He loved aunt Scorpia, but he liked going to his mom's classroom at the end of the day and watching her finish working, more.

He moved to a familiar seat in front of her desk and sat down. He folded his arms on the table and rested his chin on top as he watched the golden haired woman worked. Mom was very different from mama. She would show everything on her face; there was a wrinkle between her eyebrows and he knew that meant she had hit a snag, he saw the pencil begin to tap against her lip as she leaned away from the laptop she was working on as though she just needed to get away from the problem a little bit. Then, there it was, the problem was solved, her tongue poked out a little as she lurched back to the keyboard and began to type furiously. His mama would have just grit her teeth and made it happen, she was sharp and impatient with herself and he knew that his mom helped to balance her out in a way that he couldn't.

"Woo!" The whoop of triumph startled the little boy who had begun to lightly doze. "Come on Javi, let's go home."

Adora quickly pushed everything into her bag, happy to be done for the week and ready for the next. She always tried to make sure that she left her work in school so that she could give all of her attention to her family at home. It was tough sometimes, fitting all her marking and preparation into her workday but she would rather that than go back to her days of working at home alone in her little apartment. With her bag slung over her shoulder, she moved to the boy who was still slumped over the table. She smiled down at him, sometimes he was so like Catra. She had always been draped across something when they were

children. She reached out and ran a hand through his wild hair, feeling him lean into the touch and her heart felt full to bursting.

“Let’s go home”. She reached down and he grasped her hand, letting her pull him to his feet while he grabbed his own bag and let himself be led down the hall and out to the car.

As the pair passed Perfuma’s room, they called out a loud goodbye, making the willowy woman laugh as she waved to them. They didn’t hang around, and once they were safely in the car, Javier clicked into his car seat in the back and Adora safely ensconced behind the steering wheel, they were heading home. Javier watched the blue eyes he could see reflected in the little mirror she had attached under her rearview to be able to look at him while she drove.

“Mom, would you like to have a baby?” He wasn’t sure where the idea came from, but once it left his lips he was certain that he would really like a little brother or sister. If they were happy as a three, how much happier would they be if they were a four?

Adora was blind-sided by the question, so much so that she jerked the steering wheel, briefly crossing the centre of the road and getting several angry hoots as she righted herself and waved a sheepish apology to the driver in the next lane. It wasn’t that she hadn’t thought about having a child with Catra, she had just never expected something like that to come out of Javier’s mouth. He always seemed so content to be an only child.

“I didn’t know you wanted a little brother or sister.” Her voice sounded normal and she was thankful for all that teacher training.

“I dunno,” he shrugged a little uncomfortable as he met the eyes in the mirror. Maybe he should have said it to mama first? “My friends all have brothers and sisters. I think being a big brother would be cool. You and mama would be really happy too.”

“Hey, we’re so happy with you and each other Javi.” She reached behind her with one hand and squeezed is ankle, the only body

part she could reach.

“I know Mom. I just think a baby sister would be cool.” He wasn’t sure where the idea of a sister came from, but it felt right as he said it.

The conversation drifted, as after school conversations do, to a different topic and by the time the car turned into the carpark of Dryl they were laughing about what had happened to one of the kindergarten teachers that morning, talk of more children forgotten for now.

Clanging pans greeted the blond when she walked back into the kitchen, having left Javier to have his bath now that they had finished his homework. Dinner had been another fun Friday together. They always had a big bowl of chilli that the feline woman would throw into the crockpot before they left for work. Catra was a decent cook, she had had no choice living alone so young and raising a child, but for those same reasons she didn’t enjoy the process. Adora did most of the cooking and loved it, she had always thought that it would be tedious but there was something so fulfilling about seeing the boy and his mother enjoy the food she prepared. Catra also did all of the cleaning, which Adora considered a fair trade.

“Hey, Adora, are you staring again?” Catra threw the cheeky comment over her shoulder as she finally got the big pan stashed away in the cupboard and straightened up.

Adora couldn’t help the blush that crawled up her neck as she watched, suddenly transfixed, as her girlfriend stalked towards her. Catra’s grin was sharp, her fangs visible and Adora swallowed hard as her eyes trailed over the ragged t-shirt that barely covered the furry torso. Before she could think of a witty rejoinder, her brain short circuiting from the hotness in front of her, Catra lunged forward and wrapped her in her arms. Warm hands settled on her hips and the slightly shorter woman burrowed her face into her neck and scent marked her.

“You’re such a goober.” Catra’s low voice was full of affection as her warm breath flowed across Adora’s neck making her shiver.

“Maybe you’re just so hot you broke my brain?” She tried hard to make it sound sexy but the laugh that followed it and the eyes that pulled away to look at her said she had failed.

“I’m wearing a ratty shirt and just did the washing up, Adora, how sexy can I possibly look? You on the other hand…” she didn’t bothered finishing her words, instead sealing their lips together in a deep, exploratory kiss that ended with the feline’s back being pushed against the front of the refrigerator.

Adora pulled away, not far enough to disentangle them but enough for them to look into each others eyes. She grinned and Catra grinned back, their foreheads migrated together until they were standing just being with each other.

The slamming of the bathroom door drew them apart from each other and they laughed as they acted like teens being caught up to no good. Catra moved her hand down and linked their fingers, pulling Adora with her to the sofa, enjoying the warmth of the other woman’s skin against her palm. She flopped down onto the sofa, the soft cushions enveloping her as she pulled Adora down onto her lap. The woman was like putty in her hands and she rearranged them until she had Adora’s legs thrown over her own and was holding her almost bridal style.

“What’s got you looking all discombobulated? My kisses really that good?” She punctuated her words with quick kisses on the blond’s cheeks as she squirmed in her embrace.

“You know that they are.” Adora swatted the conveniently placed shoulder. “It’s just something that Javi on our way home from school today. It got me thinking.”

Catra’s face turned serious at her words and she moved so that they were sitting next to each other, a small sliver of sofa cushion between them but hands still linked.

“Gosh, nothing bad Catra, don’t let yourself go there. Our boy is fine, more than fine, he’s thriving, all right?” She knew that no matter how much Catra seemed to have bounced back from her ordeal two years before, there were still scars deep down that could easily be opened. She reached out and stroked her hand along an ear that had folded itself back and said more than words could about where her partner was right now.

“That’s good to know,” the feline shook her ears out purposely making herself relax back into their tangled seating position and then waited expectantly for Adora to go on.

“So, we were heading home today and Javier said that he would like a sibling.” She saw Catra’s brows raise at this, clearly just as startled as she had been by the news, “In fact, he specifically told me he would like a little sister.”

“Would he now?” Adora noticed that Catra had leaned away from her for the first time as she spoke as though wanting to distance herself from the conversation.

“I pushed him a little but he didn’t really know where the idea had come from. I think it’s just because a lot of his friends have younger siblings.” She bit her lip for a moment, this wasn’t something she had ever talked with the other woman about. In all the excitement of meeting again and the chaos of what had followed there hadn’t be a right moment and then they had been a little family of three and she hadn’t thought about other children.

Now though, she couldn’t stop the image of little, big eared child running around the apartment. “Have you ever thought about having another child?”

She looked at Catra and saw something like a light go out behind blue and yellow eyes, and found herself swallowing down something that tasted bitter.

“Adora,” She moved so that she was sitting sideways, encouraging the woman beside her to do the same until they were both cross legged, knees touching, warm furred hands clutching smooth pink ones. “I love Javier, more than I have ever loved anyone or anything…you know I would die for him. Every day that he has been in my life has been amazing.” Her words trailed off and her head bowed, hiding her face from the blond opposite who kept silent and just rubbed her thumb across her knuckles in support.

Catra drew in a ragged breath and look up with a raw intensity that left Adora breathless. “But, I cannot go through that again. Every second I was pregnant was like being trapped under that monster over and over again. The bigger my belly got, the harder it was to forget. If it hadn’t been for Scorpia and Entrapta…I don’t know where I would have been when he was born.”

Adora wanted to pull the woman into her arms, but she knew that was the worst thing that she could do right now. “So no, I haven’t ever thought about having another baby.” She smiled a tight lipped, pained smile and Adora couldn’t help but free one hand to reach up and cup a softly furred cheek, rubbing small circles with her thumb.

“I understand.” Adora’s voice was a whisper, but Catra reached up and retook her hand, eyes shifting to something new.

“No, I don’t think you do. I have never thought about having another baby because it would break me. Having a little you running around the house though? I think I could get used to that idea, it just might take me a little while is all.” They were both smiling wistfully at each other, tears in their eyes.

“I never imagined a little me.” Adora’s voice cracked over the words and Catra leaned forward to press a kiss to her lips.

“You should, she’d be adorable.”

The moment sat between them, pregnant with possibilities, broken by the sound of a young voice calling for his bedtime story.

Peals of laughter drifted through the apartment. Adora pulled her key out of the lock and closed the door behind her, hefting the paper bag of groceries onto her hip and heading towards the kitchen. Rather than calling out and letting the other occupants of the apartment know that she was home, she revelled in the sound of joy coming down the halls and smiled as she made quick work of putting away the shopping. It didn't take very long and she found herself padding her way in socked feet towards the origin of the mirth.

Soon she was standing outside the half open door of the family bathroom, the sounds of merry chaos coming from it loud and heartwarming. From where she was standing she couldn't see what was going on, other than some small wet patches gleaming on the dark tile. Unable to contain her curiosity any longer, she pushed the door fully open and the sight that greeted her had her made her burst out laughing, her voice mingling with the two in the room as they turned to look at her.

"Took you long enough, I thought you were going to stand out there all day!" Catra's voice was rough from laughing so much and Adora was compelled to move towards her as though she was on an invisible string.

"What are you two doing?" She was leaning up against Catra's side now, careful not to let any of the white foam that covered her other hand, and most of the sink and small boy, get on her.

"We are shaving my arm!" Catra's voice was filled with mirth, mirroring her sons.

Adora was glad to see that the razor that they were using was on the sink, clearly waiting for Catra to pick it up. The longer fur that was covering the floor had been taken off with the human's bikini trimmer and she wondered if it would ever work the same way again. Javier's hands and face were covered in thick shaving foam, he had more on him than his mother did.

“So you two decided you would, huh?” Catra hadn’t brought it up again since the night that had turned into a rather enjoyable romp and Adora knew that she had been mulling it over.

“Yeah, we thought it would be funny. I’m gonna take so many pictures of mama!” Javier was clearly excited but there was a slightly puzzled look on his face.

“Well, it’s a good job that I came home when I did then, isn’t it?” There was no way that the pair of them would have been able to finish the job together, no matter how flexible Catra might be and she certainly wouldn’t let eight year old Javier play with a razor.

“Yep! You’re the best.” Catra pressed a quick kiss to her lips and Javier ran up to plant a sloppier kiss on her cheek, managing to smear shaving foam on her sweater as he did. She couldn’t make herself mind though, not when the pair were in such high spirits.

“All right, let’s do this!” There was a chorus of ‘yeah!’ From her family and Adora pulled off her sweater, rolled up her sleeves and picked up the razor.

Catra looked at her girlfriend as she brandished the wickedly sharp metal. Her blue eyes were focused and her tongue was just poking out of the side of her mouth as she concentrated on the arm in front of her. Catra had her arm stretched out and propped on the edge of the sink so that she could keep as still as possible, she had spent more than enough time in the ER.

Adora took the same kind of care with the blade as she would a fine piece of china, running the wickedly sharp steel along the dense stubble that mother and son had left with the scissors. It would take more than one blade to clear away all of the hair if wanted to ensure that she did not knick the skin beneath. After the first few swipes Javier grew bored, the silly fun or before had ebbed as the more dangerous part of the endeavour began and her wandered out of the bathroom in search of a dry t-shirt and a snack.

With the sound of his parents softly talking to each other and the odd scraping sound of the razor, he drew his soaked top over his head and threw it into the hamper on his way out of the room where it landed with a moist thwack. He scratched at his belly as it growled and made his way into the kitchen shirtless. He hoisted himself up onto the counter until he was kneeling on the shiny surface, pulling open the cupboard door and making sure not to bean himself with it. Like all small boys, he couldn't wait to be tall enough to reach things without jumping or climbing. He was already as tall as his mother's shoulder and was pretty sure he would be taller than either his feline or human mothers. For now, he was just a lanky eight year old who really wanted some fruit jerky.

Back in the bathroom, Adora felt Catra's eyes studying her as she moved the blade in long strokes from wrist to elbow. She had decided to do the limb in two halves, and now that she had cleared the hair from half of it she was growing more confident that she would not maim her lover today. She moved up from her forearm to her bicep and the fur came away in long swipes until the sink and floor were covered in it and the arm. Soon she was done, Catra's arm was smooth and hairless, her still furred hand looking like a glove.

"I thought it would be all pale." Both woman looked at the naked appendage as though it were something alien. Adora reached out a finger and ran it along the newly revealed flesh and both women shuddered.

Catra turned the arm this way and that, flexing her muscles and impressed despite herself at how defined it looked without her fur. Like Adora she was surprised that her skin was a similar shade to the fur that covered it, a rich shade of brown with paler stripes. She balled her fist and started to laugh at the sight of her fur and claws at the end of an almost human arm.

"Why are you laughing?" Adora asked through her own giggles.

“I look like a poodle that’s had a trim!” Catra turned to the mirror and looked at herself, sports bra covering her chest meant that the contrast between her furred body and the shorn limb was even more stark.

Adora moved closer, carefully putting the razor on the edge of the sink and rested her head on the still furred shoulder, wrapping one arm around the feline’s waist. They looked at each other in the mirror, both caught in a moment of intimacy that had come from the mirth. Adora raised her hand and ran it down the shaven arm, from shoulder to wrist and felt the shiver race through the cat-woman.

She reversed the motion and started back up when she hit a ticklish spot that had previously been shielded by the thick fur. Catra twitched away, laughing and trying to shield the vulnerable limb. Adora got a wicked look on her face, going back in for the kill. She tickled until Catra was all but climbing into the sink trying to get away, both of them laughing and climbs of hair and shaving foam everywhere.

The commotion summoned Javier back to the room, snack consumed and newly sweat shirted. He saw his mother’s predicament and decided to help. He rushed over to the pair of women and when he saw what Adora was up to, his grin turned wicked as he started to tickle too.

Pictures scrolled across the screen, occasionally being annotated by feverish hands. All of the pictures focused on the same small group of people. A blond woman, flanked by a small boy of mixed heritage and a beast woman who looked more feline than human. There were also a handful of pictures of the child by himself or coming and going from school.

The hand on the keyboard continued to scroll forward until the watcher reached a new cache of pictures, these featuring people that were less well known to them. These were the ones who had helped them to take down the citadel. They were obviously more

dangerous than they looked. They had broken the covenant. The Light could not be extinguished even with the death of their great Lord Prime. His son and brother remained. Sacrifices would need to be made.

The chair was abruptly pushed from the table. Sliding backwards until it hit the wall as the watcher stood and stormed out of the room. A red caste behind the dead eyes and a new plan forming behind the ghoulish visage.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

So how would a shrew deal with prison life?

Stirring in her sleep, Adora rolled over and snuffled her head into her pillow. She scooted back, seeking out the warm body with her in the bed, until their bodies slotted together, spooning. An arm was thrown over her hip, on the outside of the sheets, the soft purring snores never faltering. The blond relaxed, already falling back into a deeper sleep. After a little while, hair tickled her nose and she lifted an arm to slap it away irritably, mumbling incoherently in the dark. Mumbles fading out, her arm fell on top of the one encircling her.

Adora bolted awake, the unfamiliar human arm pinning her down making her hyperventilate in panic. It was wrong, that shouldn't be there. In the pitch darkness of the room, heart beating and brain only half awake, she did the only thing that she could think of. She spun in the grip and lighting fast pulls her knees up and then kicked out with all her might. Blindly hitting something and forcing it off the bed with a thud and a yowl.

The sound of the wail did nothing to quell the adrenaline pounding through her veins and Adora found herself standing beside the bed, fists up ready to fight the intruder, still half blind in the dark.

Light sparked on at the side of the bed and her eyes snapped shut, a reflex to stop her retinas being burnt out. Blinking frantically to get used to the brightness, the room came back into focus in fuzzy greys and then vivid colour. When she could see again she look at the bed and saw a bare, brown arm on the bed, the person attached to it sitting up and looking at her with exasperated fondness.

“Adora, you have got to stop doing this, dummy.” Catra got gingerly to her feet, cautiously putting her weight on the hip that had born the brunt of the kick. It was one thing to be thrown around all day long when you’d prepared and you were ready for it, another to be launched across the room in your sleep, blissfully unaware.

Adora turned scarlet, hands covering her face as she wheeled around and ran to the small bathroom attached to their bedroom. She slammed the door behind her and leant on the sink, choking sobs starting to come from her throat as tears coursed down her face. She ran the faucet and splashed cold water on her face using her cupped hands. She could feel her chest tightening and began to count slowly, breathing in time to stop herself from spiralling. The room was quiet and when a soft knock sounded at the door, slow and tentative, she couldn’t miss it. The door was unlocked but she knew that Catra wouldn’t come in unless she told her to.

“You can come in.” Her voice was low and cracked as she spoke but she knew that the other woman’s ears would catch even the smallest sound.

The door opened slowly, as though Catra was worried that’s he would bolt. Catra cautiously put her head around the door and smiled softly at the woman who was now leaning back against the sink with her hands braced on either side of her hips, head still bent. The furred face was wearing a gentle smile and if the blond would look up she would see that her girlfriend wasn’t upset or angry. She didn’t look up though, so the feline moved closer on light feet until she was toe-to-toe with vulnerable, pale feet. She made sure her claws were sheathed on hands and feet and reached out to tip the bowed head up.

Red rimmed blue eyes met sparkling mismatched ones, Catra careful to make sure that her face was as soft as she could make it. She leant forward and pressed a kiss to pouting lips, feeling the human woman start to relax. She kept kissing until hands were

threaded in her hair and she could feel a smile threatening to break their kiss apart.

"We're all right, Adora. It was just an accident. No harm, no foul." She fulled back and stroked a flushed cheek.

"But it's happened four times now." Adora was pointing again but there was no sign of fresh tears. "I don't want to hurt you."

"Yeah, maybe I should just wear a long sleeve shirt to bed." If anything the words got her a deeper pout.

"But I like your fur against my skin!" Catra was almost expecting the words to come with a foot stomp. Sad and upset was quickly morphing into over tired and frustrated.

"We could just switch which side of the bed we sleep, it'll feel weird, but when I put my arm around you it won't be flesh arm." 'Flesh arm' was how she referred to her shaved arm. The novelty of it had worn off, it itched all the time as fur tried to grow back and was shaved down in the makeup trailer. It was now simply tiresome and there were still months of dealing with it to go.

"Huh, we could try."

They did, it was weird and a little uncomfortable, they didn't quite fit together right but before long Catra was spooning Adora and Adora had her fingers running through the fur on her arm. Both of them were snoring.

Drumming fingers on the low wall, clenching her jaw to keep from lashing out at the woman still inanely jabbering on the phone that she had been assigned to, the haughty woman waited. When she had first been locked into this place, robbed of her signature red robes and forced into sickly yellow overalls, she had let her sharp tongue get away from her and been pounced on by a gaggle of callow imbecile's. It had left her with a fat lip, bruised ribs and the knowledge that she was alone here, for now.

It had been a lesson that she had learned quickly. In this place she was more likely to catch flies with honey than vinegar, so she had bit her tongue and made herself invaluable to the very people who had beaten her in. They believed her to be their bitch, when she had neatly made them hers. Like the mindless beasts they were, manipulation wasn't difficult if you knew the right tactics. Shadow Weaver had been a master herself and then studied at the feet of a true genius of the art in Prime. No matter how ingratiated she became, how much a puppet master behind the scenes she knew herself to be, there was a time and a place for belittling and nagging and it was not during phone time.

Better to wait her turn in silence than get a slap across her already mangled face.

Finally, after having to listen to a tumult of sickening goodbyes fall from the slothful young woman on the phone, it was her turn. The younger woman shambled out of the room, barely missing jostling the crone off of her feet. Gratified that she would be the last phone call of the day, meaning that there would be no impatient prisoner behind her and that the guards were getting ready for shift change and already wondering away from their posts, she picked up the receiver from it's cradle and began to dial the familiar digits.

She knew that you were never alone here, not truly. There may not be anyone at her shoulder eavesdropping, but there was always somebody else on the other end of the phone. A tangential listener, taking notes and monitoring for keywords that would signal danger, criminal activity or every sort of dirty dealing. They were not sophisticated though, it didn't take much to be able to talk around them, to say anything that your heart desired as long as your conversational partner had the same lexicon as you. The ritual of the call began with dialling, there was no tone at her end, it was passing through checks and relays, the recipient told where the call originated and if they would take it. Of course they would take it.

With a click the call was connected and she could hear soft breaths coming down the phone. She adjusted her jumpsuit, the coarse fabric on her legs abhorrent to her as it clung uncomfortably to her thighs and groin. She longed for her long, flowing clothes. She would be back in them soon enough.

“Hello dear, how has your week been?” No names, it was easier that way. No chance of slipping and saying the wrong name on the wrong day. She had claimed to have a nephew and a niece, those were her links to the outside. It didn’t matter who picked up the phone, her usual greeting gave them a chance to talk and then she would know who was on today. It was seldom the same voice twice, but close enough not to raise eyebrows.

“Hello Aunty, I hope that you have had a good day today.” A nephew today then.

“As good as I can expect, my boy. More importantly how are things there? Is everything going well with your uncle?” Inane questions to anyone listening, a simple code but a safe one.

“Things are going extremely well Aunty. The business is really taking off. We have more clients than you would expect so soon. It won’t be long before we will be able to expand.” That was good news. Everything had not been lost.

“And you uncle, dear?” It was no good if only one part of the plan was at play.

“Oh, Uncle is also doing very well. He still needs a little help to get around the house but he can go outside now without needing supervision.” They were one step closer to what Prime had set in place should the worst happen. He may be gone but he had planned for his Light to shine on without him.

“That is good to hear. Have you heard from my lawyers?” Their coded conversations were important, but there was also the small matter of her appeal and release. Very little could go on without her, she had expertise that none of the other acolytes possessed.

“They have a date for a sentence reduction hearing. We will be there to support you. You should be hearing from your lawyer very soon.” There was the usual exchange of goodbyes and she hung up the phone with a click.

She stood, just in time to see the new guard on duty entering through the door ready to take her back to her cell. Smiling serenely to herself, she stumbled slightly as she moved to the exit, gratified when the shaven headed young man rushed to her side to take her elbow. Something she had found about being an older woman who appeared frail, was that it brought out a particular sliver of gallantry out in some of the wardens. She used that to her advantage. Patting the hand holding her elbow, she allowed herself to be guided back to her cell. Any small advantage in this place was certainly one to be exploited.

Sitting in the makeup chair was the worst part of working on a movie. It wasn’t that Catra had not experienced it before, as a stunt performer she had often had to put on more primitive versions of an actors prosthetics, but she had never had to be there for long. Now that she was the star, it was a painfully slow process. She thanked her eight year old for convincing her that shaving her arm would be awesome, as she could not imagine how much worse this would have been with her fur in the equation.

The first day the application of the appliances had taken six hours, she had been ready to crawl out of her skin before her shooting day had even begun. It had taken every bit of her willpower to not lash out at the makeup artists. Her tail had lashed frantically and only her ability to shut down, gained as a child, had let her get through it. That first week had been hell for everyone, the makeup artists had cringed every time she moved, her co-stars had given her a wide birth when they weren’t filming and the long days, made even longer by the need to removed the prosthetics, had meant that she hadn’t seen Javier awake in days. She had even made him cry with her short temper. That in turn had sent

her to her knees in tears and she had buried herself in Adora's arms, wondering if any of this was worth it.

Almost three weeks in and the process had been streamlined down to a tight three and a half hours. Pieces had been combined, some simplified for wide shots. It was still boring but it was at least bearable. Catra had realised that she needed something to do and so had downloaded several books and started to follow TV series that kept her occupied. Adora had even persuaded her to get some word games and now the two of them were in a pitch battle about who was the best. It was kind of fun to play the games and know that Adora would get a notification of what she had done.

A ruckus at the trailer door drew her attention away from a particularly interesting article about fertility treatment. Since she and Adora had talked about having another baby, the blond hadn't brought it up again, but Catra had found a few tabs open on the shared family room computer over the last few weeks and so had started to do some of her own research. She hadn't said anything to Adora, but she wanted to be prepared when Adora next wanted to talk about it. The noise at the door didn't lesson, and she was only a little bit surprised to see Sea Hawk barrelling though the place, filling it with his presence.

"Sea Hawk, what are you doing here?" She was careful not to move her arm as she turned to look at the visitor to the makeup trailer. She head a low 'thanks' from the MUA who had to keep their focus for as long as she had to sit and zone out.

Catra appraised the tall man, taking note of his unsettling lack of facial hair that made him look took young and too serious all at once. He was dressed in a tuxedo with the bowtie missing and a pair of the skinniest shoes that she had ever seen. He was very obviously not a part of her futuristic movie set.

"Fair feline! I have come to extend an invitation to our domicile for you and your family this weekend. Mermista wants to hold a barbecue as the weather will be fine and thought that Javier

would enjoy a swim." He beamed down at her, clapping a hand to her shoulder and causing her whole body to shoot, eliciting a low curse from the makeup artist as the appliance they had been applying was jostled from her hand and ended up on the floor. Catra loved how Sea hAwk would often speak like a combination of a seventeenth century admiral and the local frat bro. Nobody would ever think it if they had seen him on screen. He was almost as much of a chameleon as DT.

"I don't think we have anything on, so count us in. I'll talk to Adora when I get back tonight." It was good to have a shooting schedule that left some weekends free. "Still doesn't explain why you're here though. You could have texted."

"I was on location up the street, night shoot, and I knew you'd be here at the crack of dawn. I though you may like to see a friendly face." He was a sweet man. He looked down at his watch. "I can stay for half an hour." Catra nodded to the empty chair beside hers and smiled as he draped himself over it like the eternal teen she was sure he was.

"Anyone else coming to this shindig?" She tried to ignore the slight pinching and tugging on her arm, there was always a part that got more uncomfortable as things were glued around her elbow.

"The whole gang I think, Perfuma will bring Scorpia but you should lure Entrapta out for the day too."

"I'll do that, get her some natural vitamin D for a change." She appraised him, unable to stop looking at his top lip until he squirmed. "So what's up with the close shave?"

Sea Hawk reached up and ran his hand over the place where his luscious facial hair should be. It was obvious that he was not pleased with the development. "The director believed that it would be impactful if my character shaved off his moustache as his character developed. I thought he was wrong, but as my lovely Mermista pointed out, I am his trained monkey and it will

grow back.” She could almost hear the taciturn woman say those words to him and it made her smirk. He looked over at her, seeming to notice her fleshy hand still visible under the bulk of the prosthetics. “I can see that you too have been forced to lose some of your fleece for fame!”

Catra couldn’t help it, the man was funny without even trying, she burst into laughter, regretting it instantly as the glue holding a large chunk of rubber tore away from her arm and the laugh turned into a hiss.

Catra loved the workout room. It was one of the best parts about living in Dryl. Her apartment was amazing, far bigger and more lavish than anything that she could have had if not for Entrapta and her reckless generosity, but it was the workout room that she adored. When she, Javier, Scorpia and Entrapta had moved into the tech company building, the top floors had already been apartments and a gym area. Entrapta had been the one who had quickly decreed that each floor would only be one apartment — she had no time or inclination to become a landlord. That had initially led the too proud young woman to object, that she was to be a tenant and pay her way.

Entrapta had snorted at that but acquiesced at the time. Little had the new mother known, but the scientific genius had taken the paltry rent that she had charged and invested it for her friend until it spawned a healthy sum. The day she had handed that money to the young girl, Catra had known that these women really were the best friends she could have, as if she had ever had any doubt. She had tried to argue, foolish pride something that was hard to set down, but Entrapta had laughed her maniac laugh and shown her that she had kept all of her rent. After that, Catra hadn’t argued with the genius about money again. It was all too easy to forget that Entrapta could think circles around them when she was neglecting herself.

Scorpia stood in the middle of the large padded area, appraising her friend with a curious stare. Catra was in her usual workout

gear, except for the weird, stiff rubbed contraption on her arm. When the younger woman had asked her to come down here with her earlier, she had just assumed they were going to have a workout together and a chat before heading to Mermista's place later for lunch. When she had arrived and Adora and Javier had been absent it had been a surprise and now she was faced with this vision.

"Wildcat, what's with the arm?" Her big voice always echoed in the big open areas, bouncing off the mats and she winced at how loud she sounded but Catra's ears didn't even quiver.

"Oh, this?" She waved her arm around and although it moved, it was slower than she was used to the magicat being and less graceful. "Its what they gave me to prep stunts with to give the feel of the prosthetic. It does limit my movements about the same."

"Right, right, that makes sense but…um…why are you wearing it here with me?" She gestured down at herself with a big pincer.

"So, the director wants me to do this stunt. On paper it's pretty standard, and the stunt coordinator thinks it'll be fine, but with my arm not fully functional, I'm not sure. I don't want to practice it on a soundstage. I thought it I could practice it here, at least I've got all the padding and the chance of getting hurt is reduced." She jerked the thumb of her free hand over her shoulder and Scorpia noticed her phone was set up on a tripod in the corner. "I'm going to record us practising to show it to the stunt coordinator if it's a disaster."

"That is so smart, Catra! But why not get Aodra to help you out?" Usually the two women were inseparable in the gym, at times almost unhealthily competitive when they ere down here. Adora was probably far closer to the hybrid woman's skill level.

"Love that woman, but she's nowhere near strong enough for what I need." She was moving towards the scorpioni, holding out a storyboard page.

Scorpia's attention was piqued.

They looked through the mock-up of the stunt, and Scorpia could see that it was something similar to what she had seem Catra do hundreds of times before with negligent ease. She couldn't see why the shorter woman was so concerned but was always willing to help out and support her friend.

Catra moved away to put the papers down, before moving to the phone starting to record with a jaunty beep. She sauntered back to her friend and got a nod that she was read to go. Bouncing on her feet a couple of times, letting her claws sink a little into the padding for more traction, she charged towards the bigger woman at full speed. Just before she reached her she launched herself into the air, turning her body in the air as she began to fly over her head until she was airborne with her back to the floor and her assailant. Scorpia struck. Claws reached up and used her momentum against her to fire her into a wall. Her body was torqued and twisted, overbalanced by the extra weight to her side and she hit without grace, her ribs taking more of the impact than her arm or foot. She saw stars.

"Wow, Wildcat, you all right?" Scorpia rushed to where she was holding herself up by the wall catching her breath.

"Phew, yeah, that went about how I expected." She stretched and tested her ribs, pleased that they felt fine after the initial impact. "Lets try a few more times, I'll test out some other vaults and see if it changes anything. I wound want to take that hit on brick or asphalt."

By eleven thirty, Catra was back in her apartment, sweaty and bruised but thoroughly vindicated. She walked passed her son and girlfriend, giving them both a kiss on the cheek where they were playing chess at the kitchen table. Her perfect little nerds. She got to their bedroom, setting her phone down next to her laptop on the dresser, before pulling off her workout gear.

Showered, dressed for company and smelly pretty damn amazing, she made a quick detour to her laptop. She fired it up, keeping an eye on the time in the corner, dropping the video from her phone onto it and them emailing her director and stunt coordinator. Now waiting for a response, she closed up, pocketed her phone into her cargo shorts, and went to join her family.

Adora looked up from the kitchen table when Catra walked back in, a big smile covering her face as she saw the loose linen short and black knee length shorts she was wearing. She looked like a relaxed beech bum and it was good to see. She looked back at Javier who was already out of his seat and walking over to his mother. He was wearing a red t-shirt and very loud tie-dyed shorts. His sunglasses that had once been such a staple of his wardrobe, were perched in his hair.

"Wagon's roll folks, I don't want to face the wrath of Mermista and Glimmer!" Adora took Catra's outstretched hand, scooping up the bag that was already waiting by the door, and headed out to round up Entrapta.

Trees reached high up into the air, their green canopy swaying in the warm breeze. The air was scented with daisy and fresh mowed grass, life itself moving through the large space. It was an idyllic location for a retreat. Rustic yurts ordered a large tree bound clearing in a brown oval. Their stretched canvas and metal chimneys jutting out. They looked at once new and pristine and like they belonged embedded in nature. There were enough of the structures to house well over a hundred people, though there were far fewer quartered her at any one time. Further into the trees, nestled. So deeply that it was almost hidden from the right angle, a long wooden cabin sat. It was two stories tall but still dwarfed by the trees around it. This was the hub of this peaceful place.

Weak morning light filtered through the leaves, waking up the world after a peaceful night's sleep. A young woman, dressed in

white yoga pants and a flowing tunic left the cabin, carrying an overflowing basket with her. She moved from tent to tent, knocking on one of the wooden beams that bracketed the entrance, and calling out a cheery greeting. Each time she would enter, depositing a small package and leave again, wishing the occupants good cheer.

It was't long before she emerged from the last of the occupied yurts, basket empty, and began to hum as she walked back to the large wooden structure. She took a deep breath, raising her face and dashing the dark hair out of her eyes. It was a gorgeous day to bask in the light of the morning. She passed through the doorway into the shade of the building, passing through and raising her hands in greeting to the other early risers who were beginning to prepare for their guests to arrive for breakfast. They were all dressed just as she was, some with sunbursts embroidered on their breasts to show that they were supervisors.

Finally reaching the kitchen she put down the empty basket, moved to put an apron around her waist and joined the three other people in the room chopping fruit, mixing pancake batter and frying bacon and sausages. It was to be a feast in the long dining room that ran half the length of the building. Mornings were when all of the guests would eat together, greeting the day and setting their intentions. Activities would be set out and people would begin to separate into small groups to join their instructors. Lunch would be a far more relaxed affair and they would come together again for the evening meal.

Outside, a young man, the sunburst on his chest glinting under the warm light of the morning sun, his broad smile gleaming just as brightly, raised his hand and struck the morning gong with five sharp hits. The sound reverberated around the clearing, dissipating out into the trees sending birds scattering into the sky. Bleary eyed, but excited people stumbled out of their yurts, greeting each other with happy chatter and grins. They filed to the cabin, moving through the line of guid and instructors who had come out to flank the path. All of them bathed in light.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Bright Acres - A Place to Rest and Grow.

Chapter Notes

As a shock to exactly no-one the chapter count has gone up!

Perfuma was the best thing that had ever happened to Scorpia. She was a constant positive and supportive force in the big women's life, a love that she had been unsure that she would ever find or even deserve. Catra would joke that they had been the typical 'meet cute', though Scorpia thought that spilling an almost full iced coffee all over a woman was perhaps the least cute thing she had ever done, but it had certainly done the trick.

It had been years ago now, they were coming up to their five year anniversary and living together for just over two. When they had met, Scorpia had already been running the business side of Dryl for Entrapta while Perfuma was still in college. Scorpia had never intended to be a captain of industry, had always been pretty sure that she was equipped to be captain of exactly nothing.

As big and loud as she was, throughout her childhood her self esteem had been at rock bottom, she was clumsy and unintentionally destructive. She struggled. She had not been gifted academically in class, unable to always concentrate on what was needed and at times not understanding the social cues from her peers. She had had friends, it was hard not to, but they had been the mean girls. Bullies, tough girls who had pulled her into their clique because of her size and strength. She had let herself be drawn in, thankful to be accepted and wanted for a change. They had never really liked her though. They would come to classes on Monday talking about places they had been or things that they had done that she had never been invited to. It had

taken her too long to realise they just wanted her to stay quiet and be intimidating.

By then it had been too late. She had alienated the other students, the soft spoken nerdy ones who might have once been her friends. If she left the bullies she would have nothing. It had been a hard choice to make, she was so used to being the outsider that it had felt nice to be wanted, even if it was just for what she could do for them. In her senior year she had torn herself away from the gang of wicked girls, made herself a social pariah. She had found herself eating alone in the bathroom, hiding in open classrooms to avoid pointe fingers and mocking words. The predator now the prey.

That was how she had found herself in one of the older science labs one fateful fall afternoon. Her quadruple-XL sweatshirt soggy with 'accidentally' spilt milkshake and starting to wreak, barely holding back tears that she dare not shed in front of anyone, she had scuttled along a dark corridor in a largely unused part of the high school. There were old science rooms her that had been decommissioned, or so she thought.

With her head down and her food pulled low over her eyes, she didn't see the blur of purple till it was too late and she was tangled in what seemed to be rope, making her lose her balance and hit the floor with a painful thud. Seeing stars, yet more of her dignity in tatters as she laid on the ground, the tears finally broke through and rushed down her cheeks. She expected to hear jeers and taunting, maybe feel a swift kick to the ribs, a place that people knew was unprotected by her carapace. Instead, a gentle touch settled on her shoulders and she was effortlessly lifted to her feet.

Large, red rimmed eyes turned to this saviour, startled when instead of one of the boys from the football team, she found a short girl with a copious amount of purple hair that seemed to have a life of its own standing in front of her. Her eyes were curious as she appraised the much bigger girl in front of her.

Scorpia squirmed, feeling like a frog under a microscope, all too aware of her rumbled, smelly state.

She chewed at her lip, unsure of what to say, when the decision was taken from her hands as the purple hair whipped out and wrapped around her tail, clutching it tightly and jerking it forward. Taken off guard, nobody touched her poisonous appendage, Scorpia was whirled around. She almost didn't notice when the cap that she wore on her stinger at school was removed.

"Simply fascinating," the girl spoke as though she didn't realise that anyone else was there as she moved the appendage this way and that, getting her eye far too close for comfort to the sharp tip. It was only then that Scorpia noticed the safety goggled covering the girls face, almost lost in all the hair, and was able to relax a fraction. Still freaked out by the strange encounter.

"Um…hey…um…that's my tail." Her voice was curious and soft, the other girl not even looking up or letting go.

"You need to come with me!" There was no question there, one minute Scorpia was in a corridor and the next she was whisked into what she had thought was a deserted classroom almost as though transported there by magic, her tail still held prisoner.

"Do you have a name?" The question startled the big teen so much that she jerked, her tail moving in the purple grasp and she winced as she expected the small girl to fall into unconsciousness. She needn't have worried though, hair doesn't care about venom.

"I'm Scorpia. Who are you?" The pale haired girl was certain that she had never seen this person before either around school or in the area and yet she appeared to be around her age.

"Oh, I'm Entrapta." The girl spoke absently as she led the way over to a large and impressive looking microscope. "Subject's name is Scorpia," she spoke into a small recorder that had appeared from nowhere. "Are you venomous?" Scorpia nodded dumbly. "Can you eject some onto this slide?" Scorpia wasn't

entirely sure, she had never tried to use her venom, in fact she spent a lot of her time trying not to hurt anybody with it. Her moms told her not to be self conscious about it, they had them too, but she was still always worried in a school with no other scorpioni.

"I can try, I guess." Without much effort she made a drop of venom bead at the end of her stinger and the strange girl made a joyful cackle and manoeuvred it onto a glass slide and popped it under the magnifier. Her hair unravelled itself from the tail and she began to hum as she twisted some nobs, eyes pressed to the device and grasped a pencil scribbling frantically.

Minutes passed by and it seemed as though Scorpia had been completely forgotten. She worried at the floor with a booted foot, bowing her head again and catching a whiff of the concoction on her shirt that made her gag. Wrestling the garment over her head, not as easy as it sounded with claws, she heard a rip and sighed, balling it up and cast about for a trash can. She spotted it by the door, full to the top with snack wrappers and walked towards it.

"Oh, don't leave! Your venom is fascinating. I would love to study the make up of your armour plating." Scorpia let out a little scream and jumped as the purple blur appeared as it from nowhere in front of her. How was she able to move so fast? Was it the hair?

"Oh, well, you looked real busy there and I was just going to put this in the trash and go." The sweatshirt was taken from her hands and trashed by that amazing hair and she was praised carefully, feeling like she was under that microscope.

"Why would you do that? You're my new lab partner!" Gloved hands were clapped as though that were that and Scorpia found herself nodding in agreement, feeling rather dazed by everything.

Turning to watch the other girl go right back to the microscope, she noticed the clock on the wall. There was still twenty minutes of lunch left and so far it had been pretty eventful. Her stomach

growled as she remembered that she had not eaten, the food all over her shirt her own from a vicious whack from a former ‘friend’. She scratched at her neck with a claw and made a decision.

“Um, would you like me to get you some lunch?” She couldn’t see any evidence of real food anywhere.

“Ooooh! That would be great. I really like tiny food. Like normal food, but miniaturised. Do you think they will have any?” Her words came out in a rush and Scorpia couldn’t help but smile at this sprite of a girl.

“I think I can get you some tots and maybe there are some sliders left?”

“Yay!” She looked over and smiled and then was back to work.

Scorpia started to leave the room but before she was all the way out of the door, she heard Entrapta call out, “Thanks lab partner!”

That had been a day that changed her life.

Entrapta had trusted her with a lot over the years and that trust had made her have faith in herself. When eventually the purple haired whirlwind had started her business Scorpia had been right there with her. Now she could stand up in board rooms, give presentations with only a little stumble here or there and even give orders when she had to. The two women had grown together, and when Catra had come on the scene, another sister in their strange little family, she had helped build her up even more.

Even with all of that there had always been something missing for the scopioni and then Perfuma had been there and she had realised that she had been missing love. She had only had a few flings before, many people feeling intimidated by her size and her species. She had attempted to date another scorpion woman in her early twenties and it had ended poorly. They had shared nothing in common and Scorpia had realised that she was not actually attracted to the carapace and tail. It had made her

wonder if it was self loathing at the time, her mothers had had to sit her down and give her a talking to about attraction and that it was all right to feel attraction to people who were different.

Perfuma was, it turned out, the perfect kind of different. They had met by accident, or fate, Scorpia wasn't entirely sure. That one day of bumping into each other, literally, had turned into little visits to the same coffee shops. It had been how she made friends with Catra, and when she thought about it a spilled drink had brought her to Entrapta too. Maybe spilled beverages were her good luck charm?

Her face split into a grin when the woman on her mind walked in through the front door of their apartment. She had insisted on picking up groceries on her way home, even though Scorpia had offered. She was generous like that, never expecting the older woman to take all the responsibility. It was hard for Scorpia to break the habit of being the care giver, but over the years she had realised that what she wanted more than anything was to be cherished by somebody.

She couldn't stop herself from dashing over and relieving the willowy woman of the brown paper bags that were overflowing with fruits and vegetables, receiving a peck on the lips in thanks as Perfuma shucked off her coat and hung it up. They went to the kitchen together and with practised ease emptied the groceries onto the counter. Soon Perfuma was shooing Scorpia away to sit on one of the bar stools while she began to prepare their dinner. Conversation flowed easily between them.

"One of the parents brought me a brochure today. She thought it might be something I would be interested in, we used to go to the same yoga studio." She wiped her hands on a dishtowel and went over to where her coat was hanging by the door. Scorpia snuck a claw over the counter and snagged a piece of bell pepper, stuffing it into her mouth and enjoying the crunch.

She was still chewing happily when Perfuma came over and playfully swatted her shoulder before kissing her cheek and

placing the paper in front of her. She went back around the counter and threw the vegetables into a pan. Scorpia looked down at the beautiful woodland image on the front of the brochure. There were giant trees and a long, rustic looking cain all bathed in the warmth of setting sunlight. Bright Acres was emblazoned across the top in a golden, shiny font. 'A place to rest and grow' sat beneath the cabin invitingly. Scorpia began to read about the facilities and activities it offered and an idea started to percolate.

Strobing light flickered across the room as the TV played to itself in the corner. The sole occupant of the room was curled into a ball, blanket pulled up to his nose and ears twitching almost as much as his eyes under the closed lids. The room was only dimly lit by the light coming in from the hallway and the drone of the loading screen of the video game played on a repetitive loop. It was noisy and discordant but that did not seem to bother the small boy who's own growling snorts punctuated the synthetic beats.

Adora walked into the dingy space, empty laundry basket perched on her hip, surprised by how dark it was already. She deposited the basket on the kitchen counter and looked at the clock on the oven. She blinked, surprised that it was actually far later than she had expected, certainly past the eight year olds regular Friday night bedtime. She had been caught up in doing the chores, wanting to make sure that Catra wouldn't have to help over the weekend. Usually they took an equal part in maintaining the luxurious apartment, but the feline had barely been home over the last week. Her shooting schedule had been hectic, eating away at both her days and nights until it felt like neither Adora nor Javier had seen more than the ghost of her for days.

With no sign of the other woman, Adora went and scooped up the lanky boy, thankful for her muscles and juggled him to his room. She walked through the open door and laid him on top of his covers. She kissed his tousled hair and stepped out, shutting the door behind her.

She had barely sat down on the sofa when she heard the sound of the front door opening and a body almost fall through it. She waited, not wanting to jump on the younger woman the moment that she walked through the door, knowing that Catra liked to take a moment to decompress when she got home. She heard keys being put into the owl where they belonged and the dull thud of a bag hitting the floor.

"Have I missed him?" Adora nodded, sadly noting how Catra's ears drooped and her hopeful expression fell.

Sighing gustily the usually graceful woman plodded to the sofa and threw herself down, face first, into Adora's lap and let out a muffled scream. Adora wanted to run her fingers through the chestnut hair but when she tried found that it was matted and tangled with some kind of product. Instead she satisfied herself with stroking along her back over her shirt, relieved to feel the other woman relax.

"You need to stop doing that or I'll fall asleep right here." Catra's voice was muffled and carried an exhausted groan.

"That's not really a threat," Adora punctuated her words with a gentle rub to a velvety ear and was rewarded with a barely there purr. The teacher would be glad when the movie wrapped. The further they got into the shoot the more demands were being made of the feline, not all of them seemed to take her safety or wellbeing into consideration. Turned out that being the star was a lot less glamorous than it seemed.

Catra fidgeted and flopped over with some effort until she was looking up at her girlfriend. She smiled wanly and got a soft kiss pressed to her lips in return as Adora leaned down and began to softly rub her forehead. It was evil, the blond knew that was a surefire way to get her and her son to fall asleep. Pure evil.

"Thought you wanted to talk tonight bout sma…" what had started as a question trailed off into a vague noise as exhausted, mismatched eyes fluttered.

“I think any conversation with you right now would be one you wouldn’t remember.” Adora ran a gentle finger along a closed eyelid.

“You’re prob’ly right.” Catra managed to get back to her feet, briskly rubbing at her face before reaching down her hand to Adora.

They laced their fingers and made a slow walk to they bedroom. It was barely nine, but Adora didn’t mind. She flicked off the light on her way out of the room. In their room, Adora made quick work of pulling Catra’s shirt over her head and then slid her pants down her legs. She gently pushed Catra down onto the bed where the feline collapsed.

“I should take a shower.” Adora wasn’t sure she had ever heard Catra sound so defeated and she had seen the woman survive a kidnapping.

“Do you want to take a shower?” Adora was taking off her own clothes and pulling down the sheets.

“No but I bet I stink.”

Adora crawled across the bed and sniffed at the furred woman, who cracked open an eye to look at her with curiosity. Sure, there was an odd smell about the hybrid and her hair was weird but Adora could live with that.

“You’re fine, you can shower in the morning.” She climbed over Catra and dragged her to her feet and steered her to the bathroom so that they could do their routine, albeit more clumsily than usual.

Catra managed to head to Javier’s room and kiss him before finally clambering under the cool bedsheets in just her underwear and curling up into Adora’s arms with her head on the other woman’s chest. The steady beating of the blond’s heart was like a sedative and she was already half asleep before she spoke.

“Love you ‘Dora.”

“I love you too.” Catra was already snoring, Adora not far behind. Talk could wait for another day.

Perfuma straightened up from her final pose, taking in a big lung full of the fresh, clean air. The warm spring sunshine beat down on her and she felt absolutely at peace. She thanked the white clad instructor, a young woman with an amphibious appearance and rather flattering eyepatch that made her seem rather roguish, who had thoroughly put them through their paces over the last two days. She had helped Perfuma to improve her form in several poses that she had thought she had nailed. It was always nice to find ways to improve.

Scorpia was not with her, this little couples weekend that they had booked themselves at Bright Acres was not about being attached at the hip. Rather it was about how they could both indulge their own interests and share their happiness with each other. It was a sentiment that she very much agreed with. She loathed the idea that you were half a person and that meeting somebody else made you complete. Perfuma was perfectly herself, some might say too much so. She saw her relationship with Scorpia as them being a complimentary pair, both perfectly individual but more beautiful together. That, and Scorpia was absolutely hopeless at yoga.

She chuckled to herself as she made her way back to the yurt that they had been sharing for the last couple of days. The first time that she had tried to show Scorpia how to do yoga, thinking it would help the older woman to unwind from her job, had been an unmitigated disaster. The couple had only been dating a few weeks and Perfuma had been working two jobs to put herself through college. They had met at her first as a barista, the other was at a yoga centre. It was really flexible and meant she got to indulge her hobby and get paid for it too.

When she had suggested to Scorpia that she should come and try it out, it had mostly been to see the muscular woman in tight fitting workout gear (still one of her favourite sights). She had been so earnest and keen, only to end up with a sprained ankle and a black eye. It had turned out that although she was athletic and strong the woman was not the most flexible. Rather than putting Perfuma off, she had been endeared to the woman more.

Stepping through the canvas flap, she was delighted to see the woman who had been on her mind laying on the low bed that dominated the centre of the space. Her pinchers were laying on her stomach, moving up and down with her deep breaths as she dozed. Perfuma had left her that morning in the breakfast hall as they had gone their separate ways. She wondered what had tuckered her out so much.

She turned to the tent flap and untied it so that the two sides fell together and then pulled down the zipper. They had been told when they arrived that that was as good as putting a ‘do not disturb’ sign on the door. She moved back towards her sleeping lover, removing her yoga pants and sports bra and letting them fall to the floor unheeded. Naked, she lowered herself to the bed and laid along the length of the sorption, moving her hand along a bare bicep and revelling in the goosebumps that bloomed in their wake,

“Scorpia.” She whispered into the adorably dainty ear, warm breath ruffling her hair.

“You’re back.” Dark lips broke into a smile before Scorpia even opened her eyes. When they did open, they grew wide as saucers as she saw Perfuma’s naked state.

Perfuma looked at her with a look so lascivious that it made the bigger woman gulp. Then her own clothes were flying across the room as they both wrestled them off of her. She had wanted to tell Perfuma about her hike along the trail, but that could wait till after.

They would definitely have to tell their friends about this place.

Paper crinkled under his fingers as he briskly turned the page looking for the article that he had been promised would be in this edition. He had waited patiently for months, making the best of being in this place. It had been worth the perceived betrayal of giving over everything he knew about the Citadel. In the eyes of the public and the press he was the traitor who had turned on his organisation at the first glimpse for saving his own skin. He had handed over paperwork, dossiers and even the names of people who were working in other organisations to undermine them from the inside and push people towards his brother's ministry.

His own people had spit at him on the courthouse steps as he had been taken in, dressed in a dark suit and tie to make him look as far from them as possible. It had not been difficult to make the jury believe that he had been a slighted younger brother, living in his brother's shadow and brainwashed as assuredly as the other people in the cult. His trial had barely got off of the ground when he had been approached with a deal, as he knew he would be, everything he knew in exchange for a lesser sentence at a better prison. It had taken all he had not to laugh and smile in the face of how ridiculously gullible these people had been. It seemed that his brother had taught them all well. They were no sheep to be so easily manipulated and twisted to the desires of somebody who should have been seen as an enemy.

He had found himself placed in Plumeria, a white collar prison with some day release for those with the least heinous crimes. He had a room to himself and as much library and outdoor time as he desired. He got to read the papers on a bench outside in the sun surrounded by roses and even use the phone readily. He had no doubt that his calls were monitored but he had grown up in a world of coded speech and fell into the necessary ruses easily.

His eyes scanned down the page, hunting for his prey. He had been pardoned for his part in the kidnapping of Catra. That had made his laugh uproariously in his cell when he had been told. He

would face no charges for planting a crossbow bolt in that bitch. It had been part of the plea agreement. It angered him that she still lived free while his brother mouldered in the ground, savaged by the girl, but he was sure she had stopped looking over her shoulder and one day he would be able to exploit that failing.

A small whoop escaped him as he finally landed on the article he was looking for. He cast his eyes around furtively, there was no reaction from the other men who were tended the flowerbeds. He turned back and began to devour the information. It was small, almost lost between an advertisement for a lawn mower and an obituary for some faded star of the silver screen. There was no need for a sophisticated code here, it was meant as much for the public as for him, but for him it meant that the wheels of his plan were fully in motion. All he needed now was to hear from his people that Shadow Weaver was getting parallel. His own five year sentence was about to end early, good behaviour and a bond, with only two years tucked under his belt.

Refolding the paper, he slotted it under his arm as he rose, dusting off his pristine white slacks. He enjoyed that the prison garb here was a white shirt and trousers. It made it feel like home. His lawyer had joked that with a hat he would look like an ice cream man and he had pretended to chuckle. People were such fools, lost sheep who certainly needed a shepherd.

He walked away from the bench, swapping polite greetings with the men that he passed along the way. It had been startling how many he had been able to bring not the fold from this group of tax evaders, fraudsters and scam artists. His brother had never believed him charismatic or likeable enough to lead the Light, yet here he was building is own force of people who would replace those who had been necessary sacrifices. Enough remained on the outside to see the lIght burning, but it never hurt to replenish your forces.

Entering through the heavily reinforced doorway, passing an armed guard who looked bored to tears, he exchanged a few pleasantries, passing him the news paper. He had no need for it

now. The information had been burned into his brain and the countdown was beginning.

He headed to the laundry to press some sheets.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Three workplaces and two prisons.

Some days Glimmer wished she had followed in her mother's footsteps, not the ones of an educator, but her more political ambitions. It had surprised no-one when Angella had gone into local politics. She had always had an eye out fir the good of the little guy. When she had opened her school it had been one of her ambitions to be able to give every child the opportunity to make the best of themselves. She had been tired of teaching children who were trapped in a cycle of poverty with no way out.

Her move to local politics had started when Glimmer was in elementary school. There had been days, even weeks where her mother had seemed like a ghost in the house, moving in and out of their home only to fall into bed and pick up more papers. Glimmer and her father had done everything they could to support her. A much smaller Glimmer had taken flyers door to door, smiling cherubically at constituents and winning hearts. Her father had been the perfect host for fundraisers.

Certainly being in local politics would be a hell of a lot more fun than what she was doing right now. She sat at her desk in the busy office, papers piled around her and the sounds of phones ringing in the distance and rued her life choices. Going into law had seemed like the perfect combination of all of her talents. She was pugnacious, aggressive and single minded. She was great with strategy and could improvise on the fly when necessary. She had loved school, but the real world was turning out to be a lot less interesting than she had hoped.

Four years out of college and she was nestled deep in the heart of private practice with a full list or clients and a portfolio of won cases. All of them routine and most of them boring. It might be starting to line her pockets but she wasn't sure that it was

something that she could stick too. Corporate law was full of sharks and shisters and she wasn't a fan of either.

Perhaps it was time to consider following her mothers footsteps. There were plenty of people out there who needed good representation but couldn't afford it. She had talked with Bow about it, her sweet, sweet man all of the idea. It was just a question of whether she could step back from the relatively easy money and into a world of people who were living on the edge of a fall with nobody to catch them but her.

She tapped her pen against her lip as she read through the brief in front of her. She would arrange a sit down with her parents. She loved them and respected their opinion but sometimes they had a tendency to still treat her like a kid. She looked up, finding the calendar on the edge of her booth, and seeing the weekend circled. Her friends, the ragtag group of disparate people that had grown exponentially over the last four years, would give her a good sounding board and advice. Even if some of that might come with a little ridicule.

She laid down her pen, picking up her phone and tapping the key that would take her straight to Bow in his tiny, dingy office downtown.

Kyle was no good at being on the run. He had always been a nervous guy, had fallen easily under Prime's spell as a little boy in Shadow Weaver's house. Being cooperative and quiet had meant that he largely stayed under the wicked woman's radar. He had never been able to control his clumsiness though, the legacy of so many shattered glasses or broken plates written across his back in indelible marks that Shadow Weaver had left behind.

Going to the Light had been a relief. The Light was a kind place where you were allowed to be clean and quiet. Doing a job well was rewarded and if you did I poorly you were simply taught to do it again. As long as you showed a willingness to be better. His

clumsiness had not ever been held against him, in fact Prime had had him see a doctor who had diagnosed him as dyslexic. It had explained so much of why he had struggled with school no matter how hard he had tried and why he seemed unable to make it through a day without a trip, fall or drop. It had given him a new lease of life and he had been able to learn ways to deal with it. He had even gotten his GED under the encouragement and tutelage of the Light.

He knew that Lonnie and Rogelio had had a different experience at the Citadel though. Lonnie he had grown up with, she had been almost as prickly as Catra and just as quick to temper but Shadow Weaver had been able to easily cow her. The girl had thrived on praise and rewards and their foster mother had used it against her time and time again, leaving her often crying in her room because she wasn't good enough and lashing out at the rest of them if they dared to offer a shoulder. Kyle had received plenty of black eyes from her for daring to be kind.

She had gone to the Citadel first, a few months before him. By the time he had arrived she had been one of the white robed acolytes. There had been more of a serenity about her. She had been given a purpose and Prime had selected her as one of his personal guard early on. They had grown close when he had been assigned to her to learn the ropes and he had seen a side of her that he had always known was hiding under her tough exterior. In the Citadel she didn't need to hide herself. It had seemed perfect to bath in the light for the teens.

Rogelio had arrived a while later from one of the other Citadel's, somewhere in the north where it was a little too cold for his lizard countenance. He had been born into the family of the Light, the smallest of Brothers and raised by the whole community rather than any one parent. His calm and quiet demeanour had attracted both the former foster kids and it hadn't been long before they were an inseparable group around the place.

It had been the worst thing that they could do. Prime had already had more of an eye on the kids who came from Shadow Weaver

than many of the other new initiates, and when he saw that they had bonded he used it against them. Kyle looked back now and wondered why he didn't see it then, how he had pushed them together, giving them gifts and their own shared room and things, making them feel more special so that when even the suggestion of them being removed would make them fall into line. It had all been a manipulation. He had started as one of the Brother's who would stay in the back and prepare brochures, then been pushed out front to recruit. Prime had told him that his gentle manner and golden looks made him very appealing. He had hated it, hated being put in the limelight, but he would do anything for that man. He had had it better than his two loves though.

It hadn't taken long before being one of Prime's personal guards had transformed into doing odd jobs here and there outside the Citadel. Collect some goods here that he could only trust them with, bring back this lost Sister who had stumbled away from the flock, for forgiveness. It had been a seamless transition to being his bagmen.

The first time that Lonnie and Rogelio had been sent to beat a Brother who was trying to go to the authorities, Lonnie had come home and cowered in the corner of their room, wordless and almost catatonic. Rogelio had thrown up until all that were left were dry heaves and tears running down his scaly face. They should have run then, it should have been that they realised what the Citadel really was. But, they had been young and this had been the best home they had ever had. It was easy to fall for Prime's gentle words and explanation of why sacrifice was sometimes necessary to rekindle the power of the Light.

A lot of blood had flowed over their hands since then, ending in the fateful kidnapping that had led to Prime's death and their new found freedom. Though, whether hiding out in cheap motels and moving every week or so was freedom he wasn't sure. They were all picking up casual labour where they could and making money under the table, but the nagging fear of being found by the Light was always there. The three of them were under no illusion that the sprawling organisation was dead simply because Prime had

been removed from the picture. It had long since taken on a life of its own and spread into far more areas than the authorities could possibly imagine. The worry was giving him an ulcer. Rogelio and Lonnie seemed a lot lighter and happier though, so he couldn't really complain.

Kyle looked up from where he was crouching on the ground gathering berries gently from their bushes, nimble fingers careful not to bruise the tender and expensive fruit. His eyes moved to where Lonnie, several hundred yards ahead, was up a ladder gathering apples and placing them in the basket held aloft by Rogelio. The pair of them were talking animatedly, Lonnie laughing loudly and Rogelio grinning up at her.

Dark eyes roamed and fixed on him, Lonnie beckoning him over to them. Kyle set down his basket carefully and straightened from his crouch. He felt his back crack and enjoyed the sensation as he stretched to his full height before jogging over to them. Rogelio set down the apple catcher, wrapping an arm around his shoulders as they both looked up to the beaming Lonnie, haloed by the dappled light coming through the trees.

This was freedom, it wasn't perfect but it was more than they deserved.

It was important on days like this to be the weakest, most pathetic version of yourself. The version of yourself that people said was a good neighbour, quiet, polite. This version of yourself smiled politely and kept quiet when they needed to. You would wear your least intimidating clothes, not red and flowing, making you look bigger than you were as you glided across the room. No. Slipping a dowdy but smart beige twin set on, bundling her usually lustrous black hair into a tight bun and sliding on black flats, she looked every part the role she was to play. A simple foster parent who had been suckered into the machinations of a man so charismatic he was impossible to resist and by the time she had realised the error of her ways it had been too late. She

was not trying to prove her innocence, that had been found wanting, she was simply looking for parol. She hoped that they would see past the scars on her face, those she could not hide.

Her people on the outside had been as good as their word and provided her with a shark of a lawyer after her initial trial. There she had been represented, if you could it that by a joke of a man who had stood in front of a jury and bumbled his way through her case representation, at her first trial but she had always been destined to go away. It had taken the heat off of the escaped members of the Citadel where the murder of their leader had taken place. It had also proved enough of a distraction to the authorities to allow the other Citadels scattered around the country to break up and close their doors, the people disappearing.

Now it was time to be efficient, she had served almost two years of her ten year sentence. She had been on her best behaviour, running classes in the library to aid those who could not read. She had cooked in the kitchens, offered a shoulder to cry on for younger inmates and never drawn the attention of the guards for anything but praise. This was her first parol hearing and she knew that there were several guards who had either written her favourable recommendations or were going to speak for her. One of the best things about her lawyer was that he had managed to ensure that there was nobody to give a victim statement that could hurt her case. He had managed to have the letters that Adora and Catra were to receive intercepted and filled in with them declining to attend and with no statement. Her lawyer was a shark, he was dangerous and not afraid to break the rules if he was receiving enough money, and he was receiving more than enough.

He had managed to find some of her older foster children, those who had joined the Light in a more discrete way, who would speak on her behalf of how she had always been a good carer for them before Prime and that without his influence they believed that she could once again be a productive member of society.

Shadow Weaver sat demurely at the table in front of the parol board. She kept her hands clasped in her lap and her knees together but not crossed. Her expression was softly neutral and her lawyer sat to her left and slightly behind, the devil on her shoulder, while the small row of seats in the room were sparsely filled by their hand picked people. The board filed in, she was not their first parolee of the day not their last. It was, she had been told, the best place to be. They had lost the zeal that they would have at the start of the day but were not yet jaded by the process and ready to throw away the key. This was the sweet spot where they were looking to see the best in humanity in her. They were a small group, five in all, three grey suited men, all balding, two bespectacled and a pair of middle-aged women dressed much as she was, one short and stout the other tall and pinched. In her mind Shadow Weaver rubbed her hands in glee, these people were similar to her in age and she looked like them. It would help her cause.

The proceedings were brisk, they had a lot on their plate. They looked over her original conviction and made some disapproving sounds. They looked at the newly minted character references and spoke to three of the people present. When they turned to her, she kept her voice light and respectful, turning on the charm and confident in the seductive timbre of her own voice. Before long they were leaning towards each other, whispering in muted but excitable tones. Shadow Weaver took the opportunity to turn to her lawyer who gave her a discrete thumbs up on top of his papers.

"It is the opinion of this panel that you have shown great willingness to change and grow following your conviction. You have contributed to the lives of people without anything in return and been a model prisoner. We have heard that the negative influences on you are now dead and disbanded and hope that this will allow you to rebuilt a life that seems to have been, at one time, a boon to the community." The round man pushed his glasses further up his nose and fidgeted with his pen. "You will be given parol. You will be expected to report to your parol officer weekly, you will also be expected to attend weekly counselling.

You will be fitted with an ankle tag for the first three months, and based on your ability to follow your parol this will either be removed or you will return to jail."

The man kept on speaking, she could hear her lawyer's pen moving over paper as he took note. Shadow Weaver was elated but kept her words to a polite and, genuinely heartfelt, thanks and promise that she would follow the requirements set out.

Almost in a blur, she found herself back in her cell, gather her meagre belongings into a plastic sack before being escorted to booking to collect the clothing and effects she had when she had been incarcerated. Then she was standing outside the prison gates, broad smile on her face as she saw a black car drive up for her.

It pulled up right in front of her and a door opened all by itself and she climbed inside, laughing as a glass was offered to her and the door shut behind.

Fur ruffling as the air flew past her, Catra flipped her body in midair, the blade of the sword making enough contact with her shirt to slice it open exactly as planned. What wasn't to plan was how fast she was travelling as she careened into the sprung wall, ricocheting off and down onto the concrete. Her shoulder hit the rough ground with a crack before even her reflexes could save her and she laid there in a daze, the air one from her lungs and the pain blooming.

She was vaguely aware of a commotion around her and the sound of a voice screaming "CUT!". Feet came into view from where she was still laying on the ground, then knees as the person dropped to their knees beside her and gentle hands began to prod her to assess her injury. The medic was gentle and spoke softly, quickly coming to the realisation that it was only her shoulder that was injured. With care they helped her to sit up and then to her feet,

leading her away from the chaos on set and back to the medical trailer.

Catra's ability to focus was back by the time that they reached the trailer, though the throb in her shoulder was intense. This had been the stunt that she had been unhappy about those weeks ago with Scorpia. She had taken it to the coordinator who had assured her that things would be altered to make it workable and safe. Clearly that had just been words to appease her.

As pain started to ebb as she was given some painkillers and gentle hands manipulated her shoulder, rage started to take its place. She had known not to do the stunt and done it anyway on the assurance of the one person on set who should have her, and all of the stunt performers, safety at the forefront of their mind. Since the start of shooting she had been less than impressed with the guy's professionalism but now his incompetence couldn't be ignored.

It didn't take long for the medic to finish assessing her and for them both to come to the conclusion that she had a badly bruised, but not broken or dislocated, shoulder. She would need several days of rest away from set. It was as they were wrapping up, Catra's furred arm being put into a sling to keep her from exacerbating the swelling, that the director poked his head into the trailer.

"Catra, I am so sorry that this happened." He was a nice enough guy, big dreams and a bigger budget with very little imagination.

"Not as sorry as I am Mert. That was completely avoidable." She coiled to her feet from the bench, walking past the director and to the trailer door. She would need to have the prosthetic removed before she could do anything else.

"I know, I know. I hear you. I've spoken to Nigel and he assures me that it was simply a technical difficulty." The human man was following on her heels, making what he probably thought were

platitudes. He was wrong, she wired on him, a snarl on her face and saw him recoil from her.

"Well, if Nigel says! I told you both that stunt wasn't going to work. I worked through it at home and told Nigel it didn't work! But here we are! That man is incompetent." She was at the door of the makeup trailer now, hand raised to open the door and she made a decision on the spot. It would either end as she hoped, or she would be off the picture. Either way, she wouldn't be put at risk anymore. "I need rest for this. I'm taking the next four days, I know you have second unit stuff that can be filmed so production shouldn't be delayed. Come Monday, either Nigel is out of here or I am. He's a danger to all the stuntees."

She didn't wait for Mert to reply, walking into the makeup trailer and letting the door close behind her. The two women who were sitting in the long room were startled by her abrupt arrival, not expecting to see anyone for several hours. They got to their feet and rushed to her side taking note of the sling on her other arm.

"What the hell happened to you? I thought you were a stunt performer before this?" Tiaddy, the younger of the two women, fussed over her good arm, already applying the solvents that would allow the pieces to be removed more gently.

"T, I really am not in the mood to talk about this." Hearing the warning in the feline's voice the MUA made a zipping motion and continued to work away, her fellow artist joining her to make the process go quicker, they could both tell she was in no mood to be here.

Catra untucked her arm from the sling, pulled open the drawer of the station where she was seated, wincing as it pulls on her shoulder. She always left her cell here so that she could reach her family as soon as her shooting day ended. She grasped the device and sent a quick text to Adora. Looked like they could get together with their friends this weekend after all.

Snapping the watch to his wrist, cap pulled down low on his head, ears bound uncomfortably beneath it, he straightened and walked casually towards the exit to the rec area. There were white clad prisoners milling around all over the quad. Some were playing tennis in the purpose built court while others were playing chess in small clusters. If he squinted just right the sea of white almost looked like home. He walked with purpose to one of the spots that was supposed to be manned by a guard but often wasn't. The hubris of the minimum security guard.

There was a small gate to his left, secured with a heavy padlock and chain. It had originally been an access point for the maintenance crews, leading to another enclosed area of the prison where inmates could work on their skills as gardeners. That had been phased out when one of the gardeners had set up his own hydroponics set up with the intention of selling to the inmates. Now, that side of the prison had the overflow parking where the guards would happily park their cars away from any potential visitors who might have an axe to grind with them.

He ran his red eyes along the fence line to the stand of bushes that sat beside it, seeing the movement that he had been waiting for. He held in his smile, instead catching the eye of a disgraced accountant whom he had made many promises, and substantial deposits, too. Within moments the man was shouting out, arms flailing and drawing the attention of all of the other prisoner's and guards in the area. Hordak looked down at his watch, he had ten minutes before he would be checked on in his cell for his afternoon activity, and maybe five before the hubbub ceased.

A body ducked quickly out of the bushes, speeding to the gate that Hordak had moved in front of. There was not a camera aimed here at this time, he knew he had been watching the timings of everything for months, so with his body covering the gate and attention focused elsewhere, it didn't take long for tumble, well practiced fingers to break into the padlock and unravel the chain. The gate opened on silent hinges, they had been oiled regularly from the carpark side for just this moment. Smoothly, eyes still focused on the down man and the people ruching around

shouting words like ‘heart attack’ and ‘panic attack’, the big man stepped back through the gate as the new arrival stepped in. It was the smoothest of transitions.

Hordak briskly rewrapped the chain and clicked the padlock, walking calmly to a car that was waiting for him, leaving a man clad completely in white with long catlike ears languishing against the fence. Trying to keep calm, he reached into the wheel well and found the keys he knew would be waiting. He let himself in and started the engine, looking once more towards the fence and seeing his doppelgänger slowly walk back inside the prison and towards Hordak’s room. There were three minutes before his art class would start.

He reversed out of the space and started to drive away, seeing the crowd around the now recovered accountant dispersing and the grads regaining their posts, shaking their heads. Hordak smiled broadly, eyes cold, as he merged into the traffic on the interstate. He activated the screen on the dash to bring the sat nav to life and pressed the icon for HOME. As a mechanical female voice filled the cab, he thanked the Light that he and Prime’s father had been a promiscuous fool who had provided the Light with many almost identical half brothers who could take the heat for their purer leaders. They all bore the likeness of Prime as a badge of honour.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Everybody has to be somewhere.

Hair tickling her nose was what woke Adora. It was so unusual these days to wake up and find the warm feline body curled into here that she couldn't help but burrow closer to her back, her arms tightening around the tapered waist. Over the last few month, Catra had been up and out before the sun, the long makeup process making it a necessity if they were to get enough filmed each day. Obviously she hadn't hoped for her girlfriend to be injured on the job, she had seen her hurt enough for a lifetime, but she had a suspicion that Catra may have exaggerated the severity of her injury to her director to make point about the stunt coordinators ineptitude.

Adora tightened her arms around the furred waist, enjoying being the big spoon for a change. Catra hadn't been able to sleep on her normal side so their positions had been switched. Usually Catra preferred not to feel confined, even by her in their bed, but she seemed to have slept soundly. She was lost in thought when a tail suddenly thwacked her in the across the face. It didn't hurt but she was stunned and pulled back slightly.

"Stop being awake dummy!" Catra's voice was little more than a dull burr in the dim room.

"Not all of us are off today, remember." She wished that she could just skip school as she had never been brave enough to do as a child, but she had too many responsibilities to shirk.

"Urgh!" Catra groaned and writhed around until she flopped onto her back, looking up at the blond now propped up on her elbow. "I hate that you're so responsible!"

Adora let out a bark of laughter and Catra stuck her tongue out at her in response. This was what Adora had always wanted, to be with Catra and just exist. To love, joke and be playful. To gently be able to jibe at each other but never so deep as to leave marks. She reached out and ran her hand through Catra's short, thick hair and the prone women let out a purr and stretched into the gentle touch.

Oh how Adora wished that she could take the day off.

"Moms!" Before they could say more, a four foot tall blur streaked into the room and launched himself onto the bed, bouncing his way up until he was perched on his mother's chest, making her let out an 'oof' of air.

"Beastie! You're killin' me here!" The words were wheezed out, and though it may be a tease it was only a little one. The boy was getting heavy.

A cheeky grin and a peck on the cheek were followed by him rolling sideways until he was nestled between them. Adora smiled down at him and ran a hand through his shock of hair. Sometimes she couldn't quite believe that she had only known this boy for a little over two years, he was so deep in her heart. She couldn't love him more if he had been placed in her arms on the day of his birth.
"How are you this morning, Javi?" Her voice was soft with sleep and both felines looked at her adoringly.

"I'm great and you're both here!" Catra felt a pang, she hadn't quite realised how much her boy had been missing her during these months of filming. She was fast coming to a conclusion that she hoped her family would be understand.

"Us too, Beastie." Careful not to jostle her shoulder she leaned over and kissed him on the cheek. "Hey, how about you and I play hooky today?" She asked her son, but looked up into the blue eye's of her love as she smoke and saw her smile softly and nod.

“Woohoo!” His shout was ear splitting but it was hard not to feel the same. It felt like an age since she and her son had just had a day together. It wasn’t that she didn’t love that Adora was a part of their family now, but sometimes she itched to just climb with the boy.

“Sounds like you two have a plan.” Adora pounced on the little boy and gave him a tickle, before giving each of the beds occupants a loud kiss on the cheek and rolling off to head to the bathroom.

It wasn’t long before she heard little feet pounding their way out of the bedroom, as she put toothpaste onto the brush. She was intent on wetting the toothbrush, not noticing as Catra slipped into the room and jumping slightly when an arm wrapped around her waist. Their eyes met in the mirror and for a moment the blond seriously considered calling in sick. She wouldn’t, it would be too obvious if both she and Javier were out, but she thought about it.

Catra rested her cheek against the slightly taller woman’s shoulder, content to just hold her as she cleaned her teeth and washed her face. Javier had run off to do his ablutions and change into some run around clothes. She knew that whatever he came out wearing would give her a clue to what they would be doing today. No tree climbing with her injured shoulder though. She nuzzled her cheek against the soft cotton of Adora’s sleep shirt and decided to say the thing that had been playing on her mind for a while now.

“If I was just a stunty again, would you lose respect for me?” She was almost certain that she felt Adora sag a little with relief in her arms.

“How could I ever lose respect for you? All I want is for you to be doing something that makes you happy.” She turned, cupping Catra’s face and looking at her with all of the sincerity that she had.

"Thank the First Ones for that, I fuckin' hate being an actor!" They both laughed; both relieved for different reasons. Catra hadn't wanted to seem like a failure, while Adora hadn't wanted to sound like a nag. It was good that they were on the same page.

After a quick kiss, Catra released Adora to get dressed and made her way out to the kitchen, scratching at her furred belly and letting out a jaw splitting yawn, sharp teeth glinting in the morning light that streamed through the large windows of the apartment. She busied herself mixing up pancakes and throwing some bacon into a pan. She was humming and setting out plates next to glasses of orange juice by the time that Adora and Javier both entered the living area. They shared a smile as they saw how much more relaxed she was than she had been in a while.

"Smells good Mom!" Javier jumped onto one of the bar stools and Adora took the one beside him at a more sedate pace.

"I thought you'd both like it." Catra wasn't particularly a fan of pancakes, something she knew that almost everyone thought was sacrilege, but she had made it a point as a young mother to learn as many comfort foods as possible and as it turned out both the love of her life and her son adored them.

As they all enjoyed breakfast together, Catra tucking into far too much bacon to be healthy, she took in Javier's clothing choices. It was so odd that he could now get up and fully run his own morning. It seemed like only yesterday that she had been running around preparing bottles and changing diapers and how he had a haircut he had chosen and clothes that he had picked. His ensemble for their day of adventure was a pair of jeans, a baseball jersey and a dark red hoodie. He obviously had plans outside the house but maybe not to the park.

They talked and laughed, exchanging plans for the day and both mothers were surprised when Javier informed them that he and his mom would be heading to the Natural History Museum for the day. It was somewhere they had been before but not for a long while. Both Adora and Catra were oddly proud that he wanted to

do something educational with his day off. Adora got up from her seat and started to collect together the dirty crockery, Shen Catra took it from her and shooed her away.

"I'll do that with Javier later," She didn't miss her son sneaking off and the merest hint that he might be roped into cleaning. He was a good and helpful boy, but still a little ruffian at heart, "Don't want you getting your work duds dirty."

"Really? My 'duds'?" Adora laughed, the sound getting louder as Catra cast her a scathing look.

Catching sight of the clock on the oven, Adora was shocked how late it already was. If she didn't leave right then she would be late. She called out a goodbye to Javier who raced down the hall, threw himself into a tight hug, and raced away in the blink of an eye, leaving her a little dazed in the doorway. Catra, seeing her plight, grabbed her bag from beside the sofa and handed it to her in the doorway, their hands touched as they both held onto the strap and Adora looked up bemused when Catra didn't immediately let go.

"Hey, Adora, tonight maybe we could talk some more about turning our three into a four?" Catra's voice was soft and vulnerable. Even though Adora had originally been the one to bring it up, she was worried that it had just been idle talk.

She needn't have.

She was in Adora's arms and being thoroughly kissed so quickly that the wind was knocked out of her. Adora pulled away, looking at her with glossy eyes and the goofiest expression Catra had ever seen.

"You two have a brilliant day, and after Javier goes to bed tonight, I would love to talk about making our family even more complete!"

Early morning starts weren't the best, but to get the freshest part of the crop out to the markets it was necessary. Lonnie had never imagined that she could find such peace and satisfaction in soil and leaves, but here they were. Their shift had ended and they had retreated to a local diner that they had fallen in love with, as they did every day for lunch. This had been their longest stint in one place since they had fled from the Citadel almost two years ago. The town was small and gentle, accepting them with open arms and no questions. They were living out of a motel, but nobody treated them like transients.

"Another cup, darlin'?" The bright eyed, gently smiling, waitress named Elora was standing at the side of their table holding out the coffee pot. She had grown fond of these young people over the ensuing months that they had been in town. They were a little shifty and skittish, but worked hard and were always polite.

"No thank you Elora, we'll be getting out of your hair in a minute." Lonnie looked across the table to Rogelio and Kyle, the latter of who was slumped with his head on the bigger man's shoulder almost dozing off. It wasn't the best work for Kyle, he had always been delicate even when they were children, but he was definitely putting on some muscle.

"Yeah, thanks Elora, tell Cookie the pancakes were delicious as always." Kyle's voice was more alert than her looked, and he straightened as he spoke flashing the middle aged woman a winning smiled.

"Well my lovelies, have a good rest of your day and I will see you tomorrow." She laid their bill on the table, bustling off to the next table.

Lonnie waited for the woman's footsteps to fade away before she leaned across the table so that she could speak lowly to the men opposite. They in turn leaned towards her. There was no real need to bunch together, to shield themselves o keep their voices pitched low, but it was an old habit from a world where anything

they said could be monitored and any foot off the path would be punished.

"So, what do you two think? Do we go and look at that apartment this afternoon? I know it's small but it'd be better than a motel room." Lonnie and Kyle had been scanning the classifieds for the last few weeks, both more than ready to settle down. They hadn't seen any sign of The Light in more than six months and with Hordak and Shadow Weaver behind bars, who would even think to look for them?

Rogelio made a series of hand gestures and grunts, showing that he was on board. They couldn't run forever. Even when Prime had been leader this part of the country had not had a Citadel or a large amount of Light followers. Lonnie watched as Kyle beamed and couldn't believe that she had ever despised the caring and gentle man when they were kids.

All in agreement, Kyle and Rogelio got up to use the bathroom and Lonnie fished around in her pocket to pull out her wallet to pay for the food. She looked down, happy that her wallet was almost bulging with notes, knowing that the men could bast the same. For the first time in her life she actually felt like an independent adult. She was just looking up from counting out a small amount of bills when something outside the long window caught her eye.

A man was running across the street, careful not to be hit by passing cars but nowhere near the crosswalk. At first she wasn't sure what had caught her eye about the darkly clad figure, it wasn't like he was the only one on the street. It was when she turned and really looked at him that she knew.

Her blood froze in her veins and suddenly she couldn't breath. There was nothing but the man in her tunnel vision and a cold sweat beaded on her skin. She knew what a panic attack felt like, had felt them even before she ran from the reality of the Citadel, but there was no time for that now. If he was here then that

meant that the Light kew where they were and she couldn't let them be taken back.

Throwing the money to the cracked table, she dashed to the back hallway that held the bathrooms, almost toppling Kyle as she careened into him as Rogelio and he stepped out of the room. They saw the frantic look in her eyes and without ending words they knew it was tine to go. The trio quickly wind their way along the narrow hallway and to aback fire exit that they had disarmed the second Tim they visited this place. Old habits died hard, and neither the large lizard-kin nor his human companions were willing to trust as easily as they once had. Running through the parking lot that was nestled behind the diner, they were in their car and on the road, moving away from the town without looking back.

No words were spoken until the 'Welcome to…' sign was just a dim ghost in the rearview mirror. They wouldn't be going to see that apartment after all.

Noise polluted the tranquility of the clearing. The raucous sounds of people laughing and tussling creating a hubbub that disturbed even those most deeply into their meditation. Disapproving tuts and glowing eyes turned to the group of new arrivals who were bursting into the area from the road. They must have all arrived together in one of the infrequent shuttle busses that brought the visitors from the nearest hotel to the retreat. Clearly they were very excited and, some of the guests already there decided, quite annoying.

Sea Hawk was the first of them disgorged by the woods. He stepped into the clearing backwards, busily talking away in his booming and jovial voice, his backpack slung lazily across one shoulder and Mermista's case clutched at his side. She could carry it, she just didn't want to and he was always happy to play chivalrous spouse to his fair lady. He wasn't alone for long as Scorpia followed him out, laden down with bags and furiously

trying to shush the man, though only succeeding in making even more noise than he was.

It didn't take long before all of the others were now in the glade surrounded by yurts and looking around for one of the Bright Acres staff. Now that they were in the serene and tranquil place, their noise had dissipated somewhat, though that may have been due to the exasperated glare that Perfuma had thrown their way rather than awe of the place, although Catra could feel her palms itching to get up some of these beautiful and majestic trees.

Hitching her bag more firmly onto her good shoulder, the feline looked around the place with a shrewdly assessing eye. She counted the yurts, their placement and noted the clearly demarcated path that led into the woods where people seemed to be coming and going from. There were white clothed men and women milling around, carrying boxes and equipment here and there. They were all dressed in shorts and tunic tops with a sun on the breast. A few had dorky looking caps on. It was pretty standard summer camp fashion from what she had seen on the TV. This was just camp for crunchy hipsters.

Thinking of crunchy hipsters, she turned her attention back to her ever growing band of friends. Glimmer looked horrified by the tents, her nose scrunched up and making her looked more pugnacious than usual while Bow buzzed around her trying to upsell the place. There was no need for her to look at Scorpia to know that she was almost ready to explode with excitement to bring her friends here. Truthfully, Catra thought that her big, gentle friend needed to be careful not to let her own personality be taken over by Perfuma's quiet forcefulness.

A hand slid into her hair and she purr low, not wanting Bow to overhear, of Mermista who would just mock her and then gripe about this place if the slight frown on her usually blank face was anything to go by. She kept scoping to the place, but lent into Aodra's gentle touch. Adora was vibrating with excitement, she could feel it through the touch, and she knew that she would give the place a real try if it would make Adora happy. Neither of them

had ever gotten to go to camp, her because Shadow Weaver hated her, and Adora because that would have simply been too much freedom.

They were all still jostle and talking when they were approached by a couple of the counsellors? Therapists? Instructors? Catra wasn't really sure what they were just yet and she promised herself that she would reserve judgement over the weekend. They were both human, though one had bright red skin, though it could have been a bad sunburn the feline supposed.

"Welcome to Bright Acres. We look forward to helping you relax and grow in the time you have with us. I am Delia and this is Shom." The very average looking man nodded and Catra noticed that he was carrying a box. "It is good to some people returning and bringing new visitors. Here at Bright Acres we encourage peace, if I could ask you to limit your noise level to honour the other guests." Catra looked over and saw that Adora was blushing and looking down, still easily chided by the little things.

"To that end we are also a phone free zone. We ask that you place your electronic devices in this box, it will be locked and the key left with you and you will be able to come and access them at the cabin. The cabin is the hub of our sanctuary." The one called Shom opened up the box and held it out. The others grumbled but started to hand over their phones.

Mermista and Catra shared a look, neither one prepared to be out of reach should anything happen to Rook or Javier. Angella and Micah were fabulous and very excited to be looking after the children, Micah had a lot of very elaborate plans for building a treehouse. Angella had just looked fondly exasperated as they had left that morning.

"You're not having my phone, I need to keep in touch with my daughter." They were all startled when it was Sea Hawk who calmly spoke, none of his usual exuberance and all seriousness. It was a side of him the rest of them rarely saw but it was another reason he and Mermista were a good match.

“We understand that this is an issue for some of our guests. I would like to assure you that where the phones are stored, should one go off it will alert a member of staff and they will immediately bring the box to you.” It was hard to argue with something that seemed so reasonable, really, so with just a little reluctance everybody put their phones away.

Everybody except Catra. She was an expert at hiding contraband and had slipped her own phone into her bag while the others were talking. Adora had given her phone so at least she could have a clear conscience.

“Let us show you all to where you will be sleeping and you can leave your bags before the tour.” It didn’t seem too bad, maybe this would be a nice weekend get away with the people she cared about and a good place to finish resting her shoulder. She did wish that Javier could have some with them though.

Firelight flickered, casting shadows over the faces of the small group that were huddled around it. The glow was unable to penetrate the wood around them, feebly failing to do more than make the black grey. Though small, the heat was enough to keep them comfortable and it almost felt comforting. Or at least a little familiar.

Lonnie stared into the flames, their golds and reds reflecting in her eyes as her mind raced even as she was still. Rogelio saw her tense posture and wrapped his large tail around her, even as he laced their fingers together in his lap. She never looked away from the fire, mouth in that grim set, but she shifted until her head was resting on his shoulder and he chose to consider that a win. He turned to see where Kyle had disappeared to, it wasn’t like the timid man to get up and walk away from them, especially not when they were on the run.

Rogelio turned his long snout and saw Kyle heading back from where he had been riffling through one of the packs, for something in their meagre belongings. One of the few things that

they had kept from their days as a part of The Light was to always have a go bag, meaning that in the cab of their small truck they had a tent and enough clothes and food for a couple of days out in the wild before they had to have a plan. They'd done it before and they would do it again.

Kyle rejoined them, lowering himself down on Lonnie's other side and holding out a burner phone to her with a wane smile on his face. It was never something that they had talked about, but both he and Rogelio knew that Lonnie was the leader of their little group. He knew what they needed to do, but he would leave it to Lonnie to make the call, or not.

She looked up at him from her position nestled against the scaly shoulder and sighed, taking the small black device and tapping it against her knee. She could see his soft, doe eyes regarding her and knew what she should do. There was no way that Hordak was looking for them, it was just unlucky happenstance that had brought them all to the same little diner. No, if he was out to cause trouble for anyone it was a different family of three.

"Fine." It was the answer to a question that neither man had asked, but as she straightened up she saw Kyle smile proudly at her and heard Rogelio let out a soft snort.

"It's the right thing to do." Kyle ran his hand down her back as she began to dial a number that she had memorised by heart just before they escaped the cult, one that she wished that she had had the courage to use far earlier.

The phone rang and rang, she counted the synthetic sounds that seemed so out of place beside the nighttime creaking of the woods around them and the crackling of the fire. One turned to two, to ten and then, just as she was beginning to give up, a voice.

"Hey there, I can't come to the phone right now but leave a message and I will get back to you." It was such a sober and grown up voicemail message, it hardly seemed like Adora at all,

but then again Lonnie remembered that she was a teacher now and had to act like a grown up.

"Adora, it's Lonnie. Look, I don't want to say much but you need to know that this afternoon I saw Hordak crossing the street towards a diner in down town Plumeria. I thought he was still in jail? You should watch out for you and the cats." She hung up before she could say more, not wanting to take the chance of giving them away.

Lonnie handed the phone back to Kyle who slotted it into his pocket and leaned forward to place a gentle, almost reverent kiss on her lips. She actually blushed at the act, feeling more proud of herself for one simple act of easy bravery than she ever had in the Citadel.

Miles away, a phone screen lit up proclaiming 'new voicemail' inside a locked box filled with a dozen others.

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